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March 4, 2025

SENATE BILL NO. 555

By: Pugh

An Act relating to schools; creating the Education Regulatory Sandbox Program; providing purpose; prohibiting granting of certain exemption; requiring school districts granted certain exemption to implement certain innovation; providing term of exemption; providing for application process; requiring meeting of certain representatives to discuss proposed innovation; directing the State Department of Education to make certain recommendations; providing for approval and disapproval of applications; directing certain school districts to electronically submit annual progress reports; allowing for application of exemption renewal; prohibiting approval of renewal application if certain reports do not show certain evidence; directing the Department to collect certain information; requiring submission of certain report; providing for contents of report; providing for promulgation of rules; providing for codification; providing an effective date; and declaring an emergency.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

SECTION 1. NEW LAW A new section of law to be codified in the Oklahoma Statutes as Section 3-170 of Title 70, unless there is created a duplication in numbering, reads as follows:

A. There is hereby created the Education Regulatory Sandbox Program to exempt a school district from a specific education-

1 related statutory requirement within Title 70 of the Oklahoma
2 Statutes or an administrative rule promulgated by the State Board of
3 Education. An exemption from federal education requirements shall
4 not be granted. A school district granted an exemption pursuant to
5 this subsection shall implement an innovation that is intended to
6 improve the educational outcomes for students enrolled in the
7 district. An exemption shall be granted for a three-year period and
8 may be renewed by the State Board of Education.

9 B. 1. A school district seeking to participate in the
10 Education Regulatory Sandbox Program shall apply to the State
11 Department of Education in the manner and on a form prescribed by
12 the Department.

13 2. The application shall include:

- 14 a. the specific education-related statutory requirement
15 within Title 70 of the Oklahoma Statutes or
16 administrative rule promulgated by the State Board of
17 Education from which the district seeks an exemption,
- 18 b. the innovation the school district seeks to implement,
19 and
- 20 c. the improved educational outcome sought and the
21 metrics to be used to measure the improvement.

22 C. After an initial review of the application submitted
23 pursuant to subsection B of this section, representatives of the
24 State Department of Education shall meet with representatives of the

1 applying school district to discuss the application. Department
2 representatives shall make recommendations to the State Board of
3 Education for approval or disapproval of the applications submitted
4 pursuant to subsection B of this section. The Board shall approve
5 or disapprove the applications.

6 D. School districts granted exemptions pursuant to this section
7 shall electronically submit annual progress reports to the State
8 Department of Education.

9 E. A school district granted a three-year exemption pursuant to
10 this section may submit an application for a three-year renewal of
11 the exemption. The State Board of Education shall not approve a
12 renewal application if a school district's annual progress reports
13 submitted pursuant to subsection D of this section do not show
14 evidence of the educational outcome improvement sought in the
15 district's initial application.

16 F. Three years after implementation of the Education Regulatory
17 Sandbox Program, the State Department of Education shall collect
18 information from school districts that receive exemptions pursuant
19 to this section. The Department shall electronically submit a
20 report to the Governor, the President Pro Tempore of the Senate, and
21 the Speaker of the House of Representatives that includes the school
22 district exemption recipients, the innovation that each successful
23 applicant implemented, and the impact the innovation had on the
24 school district recipient, its students, and its staff.

1 G. The State Board of Education may promulgate rules to
2 implement the provisions of this section.

3 SECTION 2. This act shall become effective July 1, 2025.

4 SECTION 3. It being immediately necessary for the preservation
5 of the public peace, health, or safety, an emergency is hereby
6 declared to exist, by reason whereof this act shall take effect and
7 be in full force from and after its passage and approval.

8 COMMITTEE REPORT BY: COMMITTEE ON EDUCATION
9 March 4, 2025 - DO PASS
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